

Step 4: In-Class Critique and Redesign Test

Car Brand Dependability - presenter script, neutral test questions, and feedback worksheets

The most important rule

Explain your critique of the original visualization, but do not explain your Tableau redesign before classmates react to it. Confusion is evidence, not a presentation failure.

Recommended run of show

Stage	Time	What to do
1. Original	1.5-2 min	Introduce the source, metric, first impression, strengths, and critique.
2. Concept A	2 min	Show silently for 10-15 seconds, then ask neutral interpretation questions.
3. Concept B	1-2 min	Repeat the silent viewing and test whether country context helps.
4. Reveal	1 min	Explain your design intentions only after responses are recorded.
5. Discuss	1-2 min	Ask for a preferred concept and a concrete change for Step 5.

Open before class

- The original Visual Capitalist visualization.
- Tableau Public: Concept A - Ranked Brands.
- Tableau Public: Concept B - Country Context.
- Two separate feedback sheets or two printed copies of the participant page.

Tableau workbook URL

https://public.tableau.com/app/profile/shreyas.anand4069/viz/Car_Brand_Dependability_Step3/ConceptA-RankedBrands

Part 1: Introduce and Critique the Original

Suggested speaking time: 1.5-2 minutes

I chose to critique "Ranked: The Most Reliable Car Brands in the U.S.", published by Visual Capitalist and based on J.D. Power's 2024 U.S. Vehicle Dependability Study. The visualization ranks 29 car brands using problems reported per 100 vehicles, or PP100. A lower value means fewer reported problems and therefore better dependability in this study.
My first impression was that the visualization was polished and engaging. The familiar brand logos, direct value labels, and color progression made me want to locate recognizable brands and compare them. I also liked the industry average of 190 PP100 because it gave the individual values a benchmark.
What worked less well was the reading experience. The ranking was divided into two columns, so the reader had to finish one list and restart at the top of another. That interrupted the sequence and made comparisons across the midpoint harder. The visualization also did not clearly state that lower PP100 is better. The industry average looked like another brand row, and the large logos sometimes competed with the data. Important context about the sample, study period, model year, and limitations was also missing from the display.

Stephen Few effectiveness profile

Criterion	Score	Reason
Usefulness	8	Relevant consumer question and useful benchmark; not model-level guidance.
Completeness	6	All brands and values are shown, but methodology and limitations are omitted.
Perceptibility	6	Bars and labels work; the two-column split interrupts comparison.
Truthfulness	8	Values are accurate, but the metric direction requires inference.
Intuitiveness	6	Familiar chart form, but PP100 direction and average treatment add friction.
Aesthetics	9	Polished and cohesive, although the logos add visual weight.
Engagement	8	Familiar brands invite attention and personal comparison.

Part 2: Test Concept A Without Explaining It

I created two early redesign concepts. I am not going to explain them first, because I want to test whether the visuals communicate on their own. Please think aloud and tell me what you believe each visualization is saying. There are no wrong answers; confusion is useful feedback for the next iteration.

Show Concept A - Ranked Brands

- Allow 10-15 seconds of silent viewing.
- Do not explain the colors, ordering, PP100 direction, or intended audience.
- Record each interpretation before correcting or clarifying it.

Ask these questions

1. What do you think this visualization is about?
2. What do you think PP100 means?
3. Based only on the visualization, is a lower or higher value better? What gave you that impression?
4. Which brands stand out to you, and why?
5. What do you think the different colors mean?
6. Is anything surprising, confusing, or difficult to read?
7. Who do you think the intended audience is?

What you are testing

- Whether the continuous ranked list is easier to scan than the original split layout.
- Whether viewers understand the direction of PP100 without prompting.
- Whether color meaning is apparent without a legend.
- Whether the long list remains usable on a laptop or projected screen.

Do not say yet

Do not reveal that color is intended to group brands relative to the 190 PP100 industry average. If participants cannot infer it, record that as a design finding.

Part 3: Test Concept B and Reveal the Intent

Show Concept B - Country Context

- Allow another 10-15 seconds of silent viewing.
- Ask for an interpretation before defining the country calculation.

1. What is this view telling you?
2. What does 'unweighted mean PP100 across listed brands' mean to you?
3. Does the country comparison add helpful context, or does it distract from the brand-level question?
4. Which of the two concepts helped you understand the main topic faster?
5. What would you change before the final redesign?

After responses are recorded, explain your choices

Concept A replaces the original two-column layout with one continuous ranking. The brands are ordered from fewer to more reported problems, and exact values are retained. I reduced the emphasis on logos and decoration so the comparison itself receives more attention. Color groups brands according to their relationship to the 190 PP100 industry average.

Concept B tests a different question by comparing the unweighted average PP100 of the listed brands by country. This is only an exploratory comparison of the brands in the dataset; it is not an estimate of the dependability of each country's entire vehicle fleet. I included it to test whether the added context is useful or whether the direct brand ranking is the clearer final direction.

I am especially listening for whether people understand that lower PP100 is better, whether the color categories are clear without a legend, whether the long ranked list is manageable, and whether the country view adds meaningful context. Those responses will determine my changes in Step 5.

Closing line

My next step is to compare the feedback across participants, identify repeated patterns and meaningful differences, and use that evidence to decide which concept and design changes should move into the final redesign.

Participant A: Feedback Record

Use a general descriptor rather than a name or other personally identifying information.

General descriptor

First interpretation of Concept A

Interpretation of PP100 and whether lower or higher is better

Interpretation of the colors

Brands or patterns that stood out

Confusing or surprising elements

Interpretation of Concept B

Preferred concept and reason

Requested change

Participant B: Feedback Record

Use a general descriptor rather than a name or other personally identifying information.

General descriptor

First interpretation of Concept A

Interpretation of PP100 and whether lower or higher is better

Interpretation of the colors

Brands or patterns that stood out

Confusing or surprising elements

Interpretation of Concept B

Preferred concept and reason

Requested change

Post-Critique Reflection

Complete this after speaking with at least two classmates.

What did both participants understand without explanation?

Where did both participants hesitate or misunderstand the visualization?

How did their reactions differ?

Which concept did each participant prefer, and why?

What did the feedback reveal about the intended audience?

Which evidence-based changes will be made in Step 5?

Possible changes to evaluate

- Add a subtitle stating 'Lower PP100 is better.'
- Add a legend explaining the colors and the 190 PP100 benchmark.
- Add an industry-average reference line.
- Improve the fit of the 29-brand ranking for projection or laptop viewing.
- Add a concise source and methodology note.
- Remove Concept B if participants find it distracting or easy to overinterpret.

Only describe these as peer findings if participants actually mention or demonstrate the corresponding issue.